Scooter Thomas makes it to the Top of the World

By Peter Parnell

DENNIS: The call came in only a few hours ago

DAD: *(Both on phone)* Hello, son.

DENNIS: What's the matter?

DAD: Don't worry, Dennis. It's not any of us – It's your friend, Scooter.

DENNIS: Scooter Thomas, Scoots? But he's in California *(Pause)* Oh, God, no . . . . *(Put down phone) (Begins packing a suitcase – talks to audience)* How many of you out there would like to receive a phone call from your dad telling you that your best friend in high school, whom you grew up with *(Close suitcase)* has just killed himself. And you're expected to drive all night to be a pallbearer at a service taking place in, oh, less than twenty-four hours time? It's funny, like – no matter how hard you try to just get on with it, other things keep coming back. It isn't just stories, or names, or . . . or faces . . . it's . . . it's . . . this incredible sense of emptiness – you know? I guess it's just knowing I'll never see him again that's really the most upsetting thing of it all. I guess what I'm really trying to tell you about is what happened between us – Scooter and me. That is . . . because *(Start pacing to the side)* well . . . it's something that's been on my mind since this afternoon . . . .

INTRODUCTION

We all knew somebody like Scooter Thomas: the kid who was always getting called to the principal's office, who sassed the PE coach in junior high, the rebel, the outsider. The risk-taker who we all secretly wanted to be a little more like.

But teen-age rebels can have trouble adapting to the realities of adulthood. You see, our childhood is something we carry with us for the rest of our lives – the lessons learned, the relationships built or discarded. Its these experiences that shape us into the adults we become.

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SCOOTER: Psst! Tell them how I made it.

DENNIS: Scoots?

SCOOTER: Tell them how I . . .

DENNIS: Scooter, for God's sake, what are you doing here?

SCOOTER: . . . made it to the top of the world.

DENNIS: What do you mean?

SCOOTER: I made it, Dennis. Don't you understand? When it happened. You're not going to leave out the most important part! Wally would have been proud of me.

DENNIS: *(to audience)* Scooter's older brother. Now a corporate lawyer in Washington.

WALLY: Let's not take the children, dear. It's not an important affair. Just my kid brother, Scooter, who never could manage to . . .

DENNIS: Look, I realize you and he were never the closest of friends, but that's no reason at this late date for you to start in. And what kind of stupid thing was that to do anyway? Go mountain-climbing all alone and then jump.

SCOOTER: I couldn't find anyone else to go with. *(Dennis pulls something out of his pocket and hands it to Scooter).* The picture I sent you from Yosemite! I forgot about that. *(slowly)* Cathedral Peak! Dennis, that's the mountain I . . .

DENNIS: Yeah. That's what I figured. You and your mountains.

SCOOTER: Hatch's Cliff.

DENNIS: What?

(SCENE – FLASH BACK TO WHEN THEY ARE 10-YEARS-OLD)

SCOOTER: On your mark, get set . . .

DENNIS: Last one to the top is a rotten . . . *(Flash to the edge of the cliff)* Lookit how high we are!

SCOOTER: Wanna jump into the water?

DENNIS: We can't, Scoots – we're too high up. Think anybody'll find us?

SCOOTER: Nobody even knows we're up here. You didn't tell anyone didja?

DENNIS: Uh-uh.

SCOOTER: Me either.

DENNIS: Look, nobody's got know about this place, okay? It'll be our secret hiding place, okay.

SCOOTER: Promise? *(Start to shake hands)* Wait! *(Scooter produces a knife from his pocket and cuts his hand open, then hands the knife to Dennis).*

SCOOTER: Got it?

DENNIS: What do we say?

SCOOTER: I dunno, blood brothers? *(Holds out hand)*

DENNIS: Blood brothers *(Holds out hand)*

(SCENE – FLASH TO WHEN THEY ARE 13-YEARS-OLD (at school desks))

DENNIS: *(Whispers)* Oh geezo, geez. What's the capital of Peru?

SCOOTER: *(Whispers)* It's Lima

DENNIS: *(Whispers)* When did Columbus discover America?

SCOOTER: *(Whispers)* 1492

DENNIS: *(Pause – still whispering)* How come you know all this stuff, anyway? *(Scooter holds out his hand where he has written all the answers)* You can't do that, that's cheating!

SCOOTER: Relax. I'm going to wash it off.

DENNIS: You better. If Miss Palmer ever found out . . .

SCOOTER: She won't. *(Pounds fist and grinds it in, wiping off the answers)* Will she?

(SCENE – POP TO DENNIS AS EDDIE MARCUS – SCOOTER'S BROTHER'S BEST FRIEND)

EDDIE: Psst! Hey, Scooter!

SCOOTER: Eddie, whadda you doin' here? You cutting' class in high school? Is Wally goin' with ya?

EDDIE: He's waiting outside –

SCOOTER: Oh, boy. I'm coming too!

EDDIE: N-O!

SCOOTER: I'll tell my dad that you an' he . . .

EDDIE: *(Slaps Scooter)* Just shut up, ya little moron, Okay!?! Nobody'd want to go drivin' with you! You're just Wally's kid brother, ya little creep!'

SCOOTER: *(to audience)* He really got me angry when he said that. About me being Wally's kid brother. I mean, who did he think he was?

(SCENE – POP TO SCENE WITH MR. GREENBAUM – 8th GRADE)

MR. GREENBAUM: . . . . Well, the nurse seems to think you might have even broken one of his ribs.

SCOOTER: Sorry, Mr. Greenbaum, sir.

MR. GREENBAUM: Let me tell you something, Scooter. You are a very bright, young boy. You could go far. But when will you learn to follow instructions? Eighth grade isn't the end of the line.

SCOOTER: I didn't start that fight, Mr. Greenbaum.

MR. GREENBAUM: But you certainly finished it, didn't you?

SCOOTER: I'm just my brother Wally's kid brother.

MR. GREENBAUM: Then why don't you start acting like him, young man? Wallace was always one of my favorite students. He'll be a tough man to follow – even beat.

SCOOTER: Then I won't plan on trying, sir.

MR. GREENBAUM: I bet you must think you're pretty funny, don't you?

SCOOTER: Not especially, sir.

MR. GREENBAUM: Oh, yes. I think you think you're very funny. Well, let me tell you something, Scooter Thomas: You may find yourself dead before you're thirty, with the way you're going. And that would be just about the un-funniest thing of all.

(SCENE – POP TO BOTH BOYS ON HATCH'S CLIFF – SCOOTER is sitting down, throwing rocks over the edge)

DENNIS: Hey there! Didn't you hear me? I kept calling and calling down there. Nobody knew where you were . . . figured I'd try Hatch's Cliff. Why weren't you at practice.

SCOOTER: I didn't even know there was one.

DENNIS: Whaddya talkin' about. I told ya yesterday.

SCOOTER: So maybe I forgot.

DENNIS: Did Razorhead send you to Brownstein again?

SCOOTER: Yeah.

DENNIS: Look, I'm sorry I didn't raise my hand or anything when he asked who else . . . I mean, I wanted to go up to him after . . . I really did.

SCOOTER: He likes you. He wouldn't have gotten mad.

DENNIS: No, he'd have remembered from the last time . . . when we put chalk in his erasers.

SCOOTER: Yeah, what did he say?

DENNIS: *(mocking Mr. Greenbaum)* I'm very disappointed in you, Dennis. Associating yourself with the likes of Scooter Thomas. I should think you'd be embarrassed . . . *(Realizes he should not have said that. Scooter stands and throws a rock hard)* Yeah

(SCENE – POP TO AGE 16 – and throwing a football)

DENNIS: Margery Matthews?

SCOOTER: About a 6 *(Throws ball)*

DENNIS: Betsy Hamilton? *(Throws ball)*

SCOOTER: 4 . . . on Fridays a 5. *(Throws ball)*

DENNIS: Amy Lewis? *(Throws ball)* . . . Amy Lewis . . . . Scooter, Amy Lewis. Scooter are you in love with . . .

SCOOTER: What the hell kind of a lousy, stupid, moron thing is that to ask me, Dennis? *(Throws ball).*

DENNIS: I just wanted to know, that's all.

SCOOTER: Why? So you can go around and tell every idiot you see that it's true? Well, you can tell all those idiots anything you like.

DENNIS: *(Throws ball down)* What's that supposed to mean?

SCOOTER: It means . . . I just don't think it's that big a deal, that's all.

DENNIS: I suppose you think you could go all the way the first time out or something, huh? Huh?

SCOOTER: Yeah, well. Maybe I could. *(DENNIS exits – Scooter paces back and forth and talks to unseen girl off stage front)* What have I gotten myself into . . . Are you still out there? I understand if you don't want to come out. Look, I just want you to hear what I have to say. I never woulda tried to do what I did with you if it hadn't been for a stupid, crazy, insane bet I made six weeks ago with my idiot friend Dennis Wright. Anyway, I'm sorry I tried to put my tongue down your throat. I'm even sorrier it missed and got stuck in your braces. It wasn't too pleasant for me either. I hope we can still be friends . . . Okay?

(SCENE – POP TO AGE 17 – Scooter is in a car)

DENNIS: Scoots, where have you been?

SCOOTER: *(Hands on the wheel)* C'mon, Dennis, get in the car.

DENNIS: *(Gets in the car and they are moving)* Scoots, are you drunk again?

SCOOTER: Smashed, buddy, ol' pal of mine.

DENNIS: The guys and I waited all night for you to show.

SCOOTER: To the stars. Tonight I have been to the . . . you can put me right up there with the Big Dipper . . .

DENNIS: Listen, maybe I better drive. Remember what your parents . . . You've already nearly wrecked the car once . . . *(Watches stop sign go by)* Scoots – you just missed that stop sign!

SCOOTER: Was I supposed to hit it?

DENNIS: No, you were supposed to stop!

SCOOTER: Wanna honk the horn?

DENNIS: Jesus Scoots, you'll wake up the whole . . . WATCH OUT!

SCOOTER: Oooooh, we almost went over the cliff.

(SCENE – POP TO AGE 18 – playing poker)

DENNIS: Harvard.

SCOOTER: What about Yale?

DENNIS: Too tough.

SCOOTER: Dartmouth?

DENNIS: Too cold. Nobody's applying to . . . Listen Scoots, your Dad'll let you drive your car again soon. And anyway, after a year at home, once you pick up your grades, you'll be able to transfer.

SCOOTER: To where?

DENNIS: Umm . . . well . . . You can visit me on weekends.

SCOOTER: It won't be the same.

DENNIS: It'll be cool . . . You still seeing . . .

SCOOTER: Carol? Yeah. I go over a lot. She says "hi."

DENNIS: Say "hi" to her back. She like you.

SCOOTER: I like her.*(Scooter exits)*

DENNIS: *(to audience)* So, I didn't see much of him the rest of that summer. Not because . . . I don't know, I was busy working or something. I suppose it was about a year later that Scooter dropped out of college. I never did find out. It wasn't until I went home one vacation that I ran into him working behind the post office counter that I found out. And then . . . it was sometime the following fall . . . he wrote me about this fight he'd had with his father - see . . .

(SCENE)

SCOOTER'S FATHER: What the hell you doing sleeping all morning? Come on, get up and get out of it . . .

SCOOTER: Dad, it's Saturday for Christ sakes.

SCOOTER'S FATHER: What's this all about? A letter from the mental clinic of Boston Hospital. It arrived this morning. A bill for psychiatric services, it says, fifty dollars. Fifty bucks!

SCOOTER: Dad, that letter was addressed to me, you had no right . . .

SCOOTER'S FATHER: No right? A letter to my son from a looney bin and I'm not supposed to know about it? Well, I'm not gonna pay for it if you think . . .

SCOOTER: I had to go in for a check-up . . .

SCOOTER'S FATHER: What kind of a . . . . in your head?

SCOOTER: Yes!

SCOOTER'S FATHER: What was it . . . stuck up your ass?

SCOOTER: I got into a fight with somebody last month. When I went to Boston with Carol, remember? She was going out with this other buy from B.U. and . . .

SCOOTER'S FATHER: Oh, I get it. And you just tagged along. You told us you were both going to visit Dennis. But instead you followed her to Boston and . . .

SCOOTER: I couldn't help it, Dad. Carol, she lets this guy treat her so bad . . . and I . . . I love her . . . I really do!

SCOOTER'S FATHER: Love her? You love her? You don't know the first thing about love. Love means responsibility. It means being an adult, which you don't know the first thing…

SCOOTER: Look . . . just leave me alone, okay!?! Just go screw yourself!

(SCENE – POP TO AGE 26)

DENNIS: Hey, it's really nice up here, you know? I'm glad you suggested we . . . I haven't been on top of Hatch's Cliff since . . . Jesus, must have been over a year ago. Yeah . . . you still seeing . . .

SCOOTER: On and off, yeah.

DENNIS: What's she been doing?

SCOOTER: Getting married.

DENNIS: Oh, really? To that . . .

SCOOTER: Yeah . . . it's just the way it is.

DENNIS: Yeah.

SCOOTER: I've been thinking about going out to the west coast.

DENNIS: You mean to visit?

SCOOTER: Maybe to live. To get out there and . . . I don't know. Start sort of a new life for myself. I know you don't think it's a good idea.

DENNIS: What? No. I think it's fine. Great. But, have you thought about maybe going back to school . . .

SCOOTER: I know you think I'm being irresponsible. You think I can't do it.

DENNIS: No . . No . . . I didn't say . . . I just thought if maybe you went back to school . . .

(SCENE – PRESENT DAY – DENNIS IS BACK TO PACKING HIS SUITCASE)

SCOOTER: Every time you asked me a question, you didn't have to judge me . . .

DENNIS: Scooter. . . For Christ . . . I did not . . .

SCOOTER: Face it, man, you did!

DENNIS: Look. If you want to know what really made me judge you, it was all the silly little games you were playing, okay? The whole smug routine. Never telling me at all what was really going on inside your head . . . For Christ's sake, Scooter. I was your friend!

SCOOTER: Friend, yeah! Just like Mom and Dad and Wally and Eddie and Greenbaum and Carol and all those other . . . all the rest . . . who spent so much time telling me how to live my life they wouldn't even let me breathe . . .

DENNIS: Look, you're not even here – You're dead – so just GO AWAY! I won't be made to feel responsible! Just because you . . . Oh, God . . .

SCOOTER: *(Now he gets it . . . your work here is done)* I think it's time for me to get going.

DENNIS: I'm sorry, Scooter. If I did judge you, I . . . people grow older. Change. Maybe it was meant to be . . . maybe it was my fault, I . . . I had to move on . . . Say, Scoots? Listen, I . . . I hope you found what you were looking for. Up there.

SCOOTER: Found what I . . . Oh, yeah, Dennis. I did. I mean, I made it up, didn't I? And then, somehow it all suddenly . . . well, finally began to make sense. I got to go now.

DENNIS: I know, Scoots. I know.

SCOOTER: See ya, pardner. *(Exits)*

DENNIS: See ya, Scooter *(Dennis returns to packing then hears Scooter's voice echo in his memory once more)*

SCOOTER at 10: Nobody even knows we're up here. You didn't tell anyone, didja?

DENNIS as ADULT: *(Hesitates at first)* Uh-uh. Look, nobody's gotta know about this place, okay? It'll be our secret hiding place.

SCOOTER at 10: Promise . . . Wait! *(Hold up hand and traces the scar from the blood brother pact)* Got it?

DENNIS: Yeah. What do we say?

SCOOTER: I dunno. Blood brothers?

DENNIS: *(Slowly brings his hand up in the air)* Blood brothers.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Peter Parnell
ISBN: 978-0822210009
Publisher: Dramatists Play Service, Inc.
Date (Month/Year): Jan 1998

AWARD HISTORY

CA State Qualifier

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